

As the problems intensify, the need for professional help arises. If the monthly payments exceed the available income and a reduced payment plan is required, then a coach who will intercede is almost always a necessity. Often a well-trained volunteer coach can help negotiate lesser payments or a moratorium on some payments until assets can be sold. But if a negotiated settlement cannot be reached, then additional help is required. This may be a professional credit counselor, an accountant, or an attorney.

Our situation has become critical and we need to go to court.

Once the problems have reached the legal action stage, the need for outside counsel becomes highly advisable. It is critical for a debtor to understand the rules of small claims courts or perhaps the bankruptcy court. That does not mean a debtor cannot handle any of those areas without professional help. With proper knowledge anyone can. I've seen many people plead their own cases in small claims court actions and several who were able to respond to a legal judgment notice properly. But they are the exceptions.

Proverbs teaches us that a wise person seeks the counsel of others. "Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed" (Proverbs 15:22). But another proverb tells us to weigh all counsel carefully. "A simple man believes anything, but a prudent man gives thought to his steps" (Proverbs 14:15).

What about the Bible?

One point must be made clear: God will not give us a direction in opposition to what He has already given in His Word. Thus the fundamental step is for an individual to understand what the Word of God says. Once he or she knows the rules for managing God's money, life becomes much easier for both the coach and the one being coached. If someone is not willing to follow the instructions given in God's manual, the best coach in the world can't help. A coach may deal with the immediate symptoms, but they will pop up again in a different place if the root problem is not resolved.